

Saudi Arabia



Area 756,981 sq miles
(1,960,582 sq km)
Population 28.1 million
Capital Riyadh;
Jedda (administrative)
Currency Saudi riyal
Official language Arabic
Life expectancy 72 years



The world's largest oil reserves are found in the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia, where 95 percent of the land is covered in desert. Saudi Arabia contains Islam's holiest cities, Medina and Mecca. Each year, three million Muslims visit the cities for the *hajj* pilgrimage.

Oman



Area 82,031 sq miles
(212,460 sq km)
Population 2.8 million
Capital Muscat
Currency Omani rial
Official language Arabic
Life expectancy 76 years



The Sultanate of Oman is located at the entrance of the Persian Gulf. Most Omanis are Ibadi Muslims who follow an appointed leader known as the *imam*. Ibadism allows considerable freedom for women, who got the right to vote in 2002, and a few enjoy positions of authority. Oman's economy is dominated by the oil export industry.

United Arab Emirates



Area 32,000 sq miles
(82,880 sq km)
Population 7.9 million
Capital Abu Dhabi
Currency UAE dirham
Official language Arabic
Life expectancy 79 years



The United Arab Emirates (UAE) is a federation of seven states—Abu Dhabi, Dubai, Ajman, Fujairah, Ras al Khaimah, Sharjah, and Umm al Qaiwain—formed in 1971. Wealth from UAE's gas and oil exports have transformed it into a modern and well-developed country. Many foreign nationals come to UAE to work.

Yemen



Area 203,850 sq miles
(527,970 sq km)
Population 24.8 million
Capital Sana
Currency Yemeni rial
Official language Arabic
Life expectancy 62 years



Located in southern Arabia, the Republic of Yemen was formed in 1990 when two countries, the Yemen Arab Republic and the People's Democratic Republic of Yemen, came together. Yemenis are almost entirely of Arab and Bedouin descent.

Qatar



Area 4,416 sq miles
(11,437 sq km)
Population 1.9 million
Capital Doha
Currency Qatar riyal
Official language Arabic
Life expectancy 75 years



The State of Qatar is mostly flat, semiarid desert. Native Qataris were originally nomadic Bedouin. Today, the population includes a large number of workers from the Middle East, the Indian subcontinent, North Africa, and Southeast Asia. Qatar's large oil and gas reserves have made it one of the wealthiest nations in the region.

Bahrain



Area 239 sq miles
(620 sq km)
Population 1.3 million
Capital Manama
Currency Bahraini dinar
Official language Arabic
Life expectancy 76 years



Bahrain is an archipelago nation located between the Qatar peninsula and the Saudi Arabian mainland. It is the smallest and most densely populated Arab nation, as well as the most liberal. Since 2000, Bahrain has allowed women to participate in politics. It was the first Gulf state to export oil, though its reserves are now almost depleted.

Kuwait



Area 6,880 sq miles
(17,820 sq km)
Population 2.8 million
Capital Kuwait City
Currency Kuwaiti dinar
Official language Arabic
Life expectancy 78 years



With its huge oil and gas reserves, Kuwait is among the world's leading oil producers. It was invaded and occupied by Iraq in 1990, but was liberated by US-led forces in 1991. Kuwait's oil wealth has drawn in thousands of workers from other Arab countries and South Asia. There are more foreign nationals living here than native Kuwaitis.



▲ MOCHA COFFEE BEANS
Coffee beans from the city of Mocha, Yemen, are prized for their distinctive rich flavor.



▲ BURJ AL ARAB, DUBAI
One of the most iconic buildings in the world is the Burj Al Arab. This luxury hotel, resembling a ship's sail, stands 1,053 ft (321 m) tall.